

IF THE SHOE FITS
SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at an event commemorating former Brahmin party leader Janeshwar Mishra, Lucknow, Aug. 5

SUMIT KUMAR

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TWICE-BORN SP's BRAHMIN RITUALS

Akhilesh does what Mayawati did in 2007, repositioning SP as a Brahmin-friendly and pro-Hindu party. The idea is to target a key saffron base post Ayodhya

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

P FOR PANDIT. AS MUCH AS WHAT IT ORIGINALLY stood for. With that neat semantic extension to its 'PDA' plank, the Samajwadi Party (SP) hopes to alter entrenched voting behaviour in Uttar Pradesh. The original expansion of PDA—Pichhda, Dalit, Alpasankhyak—already signalled the SP's wish to break its embankments by placing Dalits between its two traditional backers, backwards and minorities. That 'big tent' is now getting more spacious.

At a Brahmin conference in Lucknow on August 5, Akhilesh said it sans ambiguity: "The P in PDA could also stand for Pandit." The event, too, was organised around the late SP leader Janeshwar Mishra's birth anniversary. Rediscovering a Brahmin from its old ranks was tactical genius, even if the imagery was of the sort that the old Lohiaite might have balked at—Mishra was a man who had given up orthodoxy and lived and perished as a socialist. But here were tridents, *damrus* and Shiva *tandava stotram* chants. Akhilesh also spoke of Parashuram and Ganga Maiyya, invoking Mishra as a sign of the SP's connection with Brahmins.

POST-MANDAL EXPANSION

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), too, had made this pivot before the 2007 assembly election—calling its elephant 'none other than Ganesha', creating an unlikely Dalit-Brahmin alliance. That bore fruit: it won a commanding 206 seats out of a total 403. Twenty years later, the SP is plotting the same escape out of its image trap. Once accused by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of representing little beyond the Muslim-Yadav combination, it has spent recent years wooing the Dalits. Now, it's looking beyond—targeting turf seen to be deep within the BJP's core zone.

Of late, Akhilesh has been speaking openly about Hindu themes, engaging with pontiffs and publicly embracing *dharmic* motifs—positioning himself not as an antagonist, but as a cleaner vehicle of its culture. A meeting with Shankaracharya Swami Avimukteshwarananda of the Jyotir Math came amid the donation theft controversy at Ayodhya. Then came the tactical strike that, in chess, would count as a discovered attack combined with a fork: the early declaration of former MLA Pawan Pandey as candi-